

AP PHOTO JOHN RAULX



STRAIGHT TALKER: Joe Biden meets his supporters at one of the campaign meetings in Florida

who are not content to settle for the world as it is; who have the courage to remake the world as it should be." McCain too sees his personal struggle as an initiation into a higher patriotic mission: "I fell in love with my country when I was a prisoner in someone else's. I loved it not just for the many comforts of life here. I loved it for its decency; for its faith in the wisdom, justice, and goodness of its people. I loved it because it was not just a place, but an idea, a cause worth fighting for. I was never the same again. I wasn't my own man anymore. I was my country's."

That is why, if elected, each candidate will bring a sense of "otherness" to the presidency—an Americanism that is not exclusivist but imbued with different cultural memories. More so in the case of Obama, who first saw the world outside America as a six-year-old boy in the dispossessed streets of Jakarta, when his mother, a white, moved to the city after her second marriage to an Indonesian. That is why hardcore Obamaniacs who can't any longer tolerate the arrogant, culturally insensitive Pax Americana are thrilled about the possibility of a president whose worldview is not entirely conditioned by the make believe of Washington. He has breathed other cultures. His campaign, according to author and columnist Russell Baker, has a mythical ring to it: "Obama is 47 years old; McCain is

72, old enough to be Obama's father. This unusual age spread between presidential candidates brings to mind a wide variety of familiar literary plots about father-and-son-conflicts. In classical mythology, the son must kill the father to allow for earth's renewal...". For America's renewal, Obama has to overcome a fighter who is known for staging heroic comebacks.

The fight has already reached the post-biography phase. The story of America, for so long the power infallible, has overtaken the story of the candidates. Today, the question is: who is better suited to take charge of a superpower wracked by economic and military anxieties? The land of Adam Smith is no longer the undisputed master of the universe, and capitalism is behaving in such a manner that only Karl Marx can afford to smile from the marketplace, which is kept alive by state-sanctioned Prozac. Once again, it's the economy, stupid! And no candidate, spendthrift liberal or wealth-creating right-winger, wants to look stupid. In the middle of a historical



Biden may have been UNDIPLOMATIC when he said Obama will be tested severely early in his presidency.